

Design Rationale

Leadership Portfolio Redesign · DeepThought Product Management Internship Assignment

Overview

The Leadership Portfolio previously read as a dashboard: metric widgets with equal visual weight, optimized for monitoring rather than reflection. This redesign works from one real employee's data (Rajan Iyer, Production Planning Lead, March 2026) to turn that data into a document he would be comfortable handing to a mentor — a career artifact, not a status board. Every element on the page maps to a field in **data-model.ts**; no data was invented.

Key Design Decisions

1. The signal is a sentence, not a score.

The page opens with “Breakthrough month — best delivery yet, one clear gap to close,” with the composite score (71, up from 64) placed secondary, beside it. A score ring or letter grade was considered and rejected: a sentence carries the story-first tone the brief asks for, while the number still satisfies a reader (e.g. a supervisor) who wants a quick numeric anchor.

2. Section weight is deliberately uneven.

Executive Summary, Contribution Highlights, and Capability Growth are full-size and always visible, since they carry the richest data and clearest narrative arc. KPI Impact, Constraint Patterns, and Career Trajectory are compact, collapsed-by-default cards. This directly answers the brief's warning against “metric soup” — six equal-sized sections would compete for attention instead of building toward one impression.

3. Narrative leads, data follows, inside every section.

Each section opens with the written narrative and follows it immediately with the supporting numbers as small evidence chips (e.g. “16/20 delivered · 7 original documents”), rather than leading with a stat block. This keeps the read feeling personal first, verifiable second.

4. Constraints lead with resolution, not with the count of problems.

The blockers section headline reads “5 of 8 resolved” rather than “8 constraints raised.” Open items (the contract-lab turnaround, the second-shift supervisor vacancy) are shown with a quiet dashed outline tag rather than a red alert, and the narrative explicitly credits Rajan for the one blocker he personally resolved by changing the review process. The intent is to make this section read as honest professional reporting, not a complaint log.

5. A decorative idea was tested and removed.

An early version included a circular “VERIFIED” stamp badge, visualizing PDGMS's claim that every number is checked, not self-reported. On review it read closer to a bureaucratic seal than the “personal, dignified” tone the brief calls for, so it was cut in favor of a plainer identity block. This reversal is included deliberately — deciding what to cut was as much a design decision as deciding what to add.

Design Challenges Addressed

Challenge 1 — The Signal:

Resolved in favor of a short human sentence with a secondary numeric anchor (see Decision 1).

Challenge 3 — Six Sections, Too Many?:

Resolved by weighting three sections as primary and three as collapsed detail, rather than removing any section outright — every axis in the data model still has a place on the page (see Decision 2).

Challenge 4 — Constraints, Honesty Without Anxiety:

Resolved by leading with the resolution rate and crediting the process fix Rajan made himself, while still surfacing the two genuinely open, unresolved blockers rather than hiding them (see Decision 4).

Challenge 5 — Portability and Identity:

Career levels are labelled with their plain-language meaning (e.g. “V2 · Manager,” “V3 · Program Lead”) rather than the bare V-code alone, so the page still makes sense to a reader who has never used PDGMS. This is also why the stamp badge was cut (see Decision 5) — it depended on knowing the org's internal verification language to make sense.

What I'd Do With More Time

- Test the narrative-first ordering with an actual supervisor, since the brief notes this audience may prefer numbers first — the current design may need a second, data-first view for that reader.
- Add a print stylesheet; this document is meant to outlive the employee's tenure and may be printed or saved as a PDF, and the current ruled-paper background would not print cleanly.
- Run a proper accessibility pass (colour contrast on the lighter grey text, aria-labels on the expandable sections) rather than relying on visual review alone.
- Show the causal link between the Constraint Patterns section and the KPI miss it caused (the HEPA filter delay against the batch success rate) more directly, perhaps with a cross-reference link rather than repeating the explanation in both places.

Assumptions Made

- Capability Growth shows five axis scores (Delivery, Original Work, Engagement, Process, Frameworks) rather than six, excluding the KPI axis score since KPIs already have a dedicated section — showing it twice seemed redundant rather than additive.
- The month-navigation strip (Feb / March / April) is presented for layout completeness per the brief's hard constraint on month-scoping; it is not wired to real navigation in this static prototype.
- The three compact sections use native HTML `<details>` elements for expand/collapse, which satisfies the brief's note that interactivity is a bonus but not required, without needing JavaScript.